

Activity 5 — IDEO Shopping Cart — Volume, Then Judgement

Course: Generative AI for Agile Project Management

Course Code: C324

Topic 02: Problem Framing and Ideation: Leveraging Design Thinking and Generative AI

Duration: 50 minutes

Group size: 3–5 participants

Tools: Design Thinking Studio, ChatGPT or Microsoft Copilot

Learning Outcome Addressed

LO2 · LO4 · A3 — Ideation and brainstorming techniques enhanced by generative AI.

The Real Case

In 1999, ABC's Nightline gave the design firm IDEO five days to redesign the supermarket shopping cart on camera. The team did not start by designing. They went out and observed shoppers, interviewed store managers about theft and maintenance, and talked to a child-safety expert. They then ran structured brainstorms under explicit rules — defer judgement, encourage wild ideas, build on others' ideas, go for quantity, be visual — and generated a large volume of concepts before converging. The result was a modular cart with detachable hand baskets, a child seat designed for safety, and a scanning system that skipped the checkout queue. Crucially it was never meant for mass production; it was a provocation that demonstrated the process. The famous rule from that studio: separate idea generation from idea evaluation, because judging while generating kills the unusual ideas first.

Your Scenario

Carry forward the top-voted How Might We question from Activity 4. Your team has 25 minutes to generate and converge on ideas for the polyclinic screening challenge, with a GenAI tool available as an idea multiplier.

What You Will Do

Learners run a disciplined divergence–convergence cycle using Crazy 8s and structured brainstorming, amplify it with GenAI, then converge with dot voting — experiencing directly why mixing generation and evaluation suppresses the best ideas.

What You Will Produce

A populated Ideate stage — brainstorming board, Crazy 8s, categorised ideas and a voted shortlist of three concepts to prototype.

Step-by-Step Instructions

1. Open the Ideate stage in the Design Thinking Studio workspace.

2. Round 1 — silent, manual. Each person posts at least four ideas into Brainstorming Board. No discussion, no judging.
3. Round 2 — Crazy 8s. Eight rapid variations on the most promising idea, posted into Crazy 8s Ideas.
4. Round 3 — AI amplification. Prompt: 'Give 15 diverse solution concepts for [your HMW question], including 3 deliberately unconventional ones.'
5. Post only the AI ideas that add something your group did not already have.
6. Group everything into themes using Idea Categories.
7. Dot vote in Voting & Prioritisation and shortlist the top three concepts.
8. Record in the workspace which of the three shortlisted ideas came from a human and which from the AI.

Discussion Questions

1. IDEO's rules include 'defer judgement' and 'encourage wild ideas'. What actually happens in a meeting when these are not enforced?
2. You generated ideas manually, then with AI. Compare the two sets — which was more diverse, and which was more useful?
3. The cart was never mass-produced. What is the value of a prototype that was never meant to ship?
4. Under what conditions does GenAI reduce the diversity of ideas in a room instead of increasing it?
5. Who should have the final vote on which idea proceeds — and what does that choice say about your organisation?

How You Know You Are Done

Your Ideate stage shows a clear divergence phase and a separate convergence phase, with three shortlisted concepts and their provenance recorded.

Debrief — What the Room Should Conclude

Two effects usually show up in the room. First, the manual round produces fewer ideas but more surprising ones, because they come from lived context the model does not have; the AI round produces more ideas but they cluster around the conventional centre of the training distribution. The productive pattern is manual-first, then AI to extend — running AI first anchors everyone to its framing and measurably narrows the room. Second, groups that skip the 'defer judgement' rule converge far too early on the safe idea. The IDEO cart matters precisely because it was never shipped: a prototype's job is to make an idea arguable and testable, not to be the final answer. Dot voting is not democracy for its own sake — it surfaces which ideas the group can actually rally behind before anyone spends money.
